

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE COMOROS

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

On the island of **Mohéli**, communities built one of the Indian Ocean's pioneering community-managed marine parks, brought their turtles back through village conservation, and, in places, halted the mining of the very beaches the turtles need — a proof that the islands' own communities, governing their own resources, can turn the harm around. The Comoros is a small, poor, politically fragile archipelago of steep volcanic islands at the northern end of the Mozambique Channel, and its coasts are being eaten away — not chiefly by an outside developer, but by beach and coral sand dug for building, by destructive dynamite-and-poison fishing, by the felling of mangroves for materials, and by the soil that washes off deforested hillsides to smother the fringing reefs. These harms are rooted in real poverty and a fast-growing population, and are carried out by the very communities they most hurt. But Mohéli showed the answer, and it is a home-grown one.

The Mohéli communities drew on tools available to communities across the Comoros, and the first is self-governance itself. **Community-based conservation and co-management** — the Mohéli marine-park model — is the proven, distinctive lever: communities governing their own resources have already halted harm and brought the turtles back. The **marine and national park designations**, and the expanding network of them, give that governance a durable legal structure. The **village councils and traditional authority** are the real governing power at the local level and the foundation of community self-governance; the work here is open and lawful. The **living value of the reefs, turtles, and beaches** — worth more alive, as fisheries and as the draw for visitors, than destroyed — is a powerful, evidence-based argument. The **international conservation and restoration partners** fund and support the community conservation a poor state cannot fund alone. And where the threat is an outside development rather than community-driven harm, the **environmental assessment** is a further gate. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The harm is largely poverty-driven and community-driven — carried out by the very communities it hurts — so it cannot be met by enforcement alone: better livelihoods (eco-tourism, sustainable fishing, alternatives to beach sand) must accompany conservation, or it will not hold. The state is fragile and its enforcement weak. The pressures of poverty and a fast-growing population are structural and hard to relieve. And the successes so far are real but local and partial. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a community governing its resources, a beach and its turtles saved, the harm turned around island by island, as Mohéli did — paired always with the livelihoods that make it last.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by fighting an outside enemy but, as Mohéli did, by helping communities govern their own resources — building community-based conservation and marine parks through the village and traditional authority, grounding it in the living value of the reefs and turtles, funding it through the international partners, and pairing it always with the better livelihoods that answer the poverty driving the harm. Where an outside development threatens, the environmental assessment and the parks are the gate.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Comoros is unusual: much of the harm is driven by the communities' own poverty, so the fight is less against an enemy than for self-governance and better livelihoods. That is the first honest truth. The state is

fragile, enforcement is weak, and the pressures of poverty and population are structural. And the successes, real as they are, remain local and partial. So aim at the winnable and the proven — a community park built, a beach saved, a livelihood offered — knowing the model works island by island, and that conservation without livelihood will not hold.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Comorian harm runs through levels that are, unusually, mostly within the community itself. The **coastal communities**, in their poverty, both cause the harm and hold the power to end it — through their own governance, offered alternatives. The **village councils and traditional authority** are the real governing power at the local level. The **marine and national parks and their co-management** — the Mohéli model and the expanding network — are the proven structure. And the **state and its international partners** support and fund what a poor state cannot fund alone. Map where the harm and the power actually sit — usually in the community — before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

Community-driven harm advances daily through poverty — the sand dug, the reef dynamited, the mangrove felled. The point of entry is the community itself: building the co-management, the park, and the livelihood alternatives that let the community govern its own resources, as Mohéli did. Where an outside development threatens instead, the environmental assessment and the park designations are the gate to engage. Either way, the village and traditional authority are the foundation.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the poverty: what need drives the sand mining, the destructive fishing, the felling, and what alternative livelihood could replace it. Follow the value: what the reefs and turtles are worth alive, as fisheries and tourism. Follow the support: which international conservation and restoration partners can fund the community conservation. For an outside project, follow the permission: the environmental assessment and the park protections it must satisfy. The leverage lies in self-governance, livelihood, the living value, and the international support.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Enforcement by a fragile state is weak, so the real watchers are the community and its structures: the village and traditional authority, the marine and national park co-management, and the international conservation partners who fund and support them. For an outside development, the environmental assessment and the park framework are the formal channels. These are the structures a case is built to strengthen and engage.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition to harm in the Comoros has genuinely worked — Mohéli built a community marine park, brought its turtles back, and halted beach mining. The single most decisive move is **building community-based conservation paired with livelihood alternatives**, because the harm is poverty-driven and community-driven, so it can only be turned around by communities governing their own resources with better livelihoods, not by enforcement alone. The park designations give the governance durable structure; the village and traditional authority are its foundation; the living value of the reefs is its argument; the

international partners fund it. The realistic prize is the harm turned around island by island, community by community — real, proven, but local and partial, and lasting only where livelihood accompanies it.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the sand mining, the destructive fishing, the mangrove felling, the reef smothering, or an outside development. **What drives it?** — the poverty and need behind community harm, or the developer behind an outside project. **What alternative or gate exists?** — a better livelihood, a community park, or the environmental assessment. **Who governs it?** — the village and traditional authority, the co-management structure. **What partner can fund it?** — the international conservation partners. Pick the harm where a community park and livelihood alternative can turn it around — as Mohéli did — or, for an outside project, where the assessment and parks offer the gate.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm and the value** — the sand mining, destructive fishing, or felling, and the living value of the reefs, turtles, and beaches it destroys, worth more alive. **Layer two: the driver and the alternative** — the poverty and need behind the harm, and the livelihood alternative that could replace it, or, for an outside project, the assessment and park protections. **Layer three: the governance and the partner** — the village and traditional authority to build through, the co-management or park to establish, and the international partner to fund it. A case built on the living value of the reefs and a credible livelihood alternative — governed by the community — is the one Mohéli proved.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm-and-value record**: the sand mining, destructive fishing, and felling, and the reef, turtle, and fisheries value at stake. Gather the **driver-and-alternative record**: the poverty behind the harm, and the eco-tourism, sustainable fishing, and sand alternatives that could replace it. Gather the **governance record**: the village and traditional authority, the Mohéli model and the park network. Gather the **partner record**: the international conservation and restoration partners who fund community conservation. For an outside project, gather the **assessment record**: the environmental assessment and park protections. Most of this is reachable through the community and its partners.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

The Comorian coalition is the community itself. Build it through the **village councils and traditional authority**, the real governing power; the **coastal communities**, whose poverty drives the harm and whose governance can end it; the **fishers and turtle-monitoring villagers**; and the **international conservation partners** who fund and support. Because the harm is poverty-driven, the coalition must offer better livelihoods, not blame — eco-tourism, sustainable fishing, alternatives to beach sand — so that ending the harm also feeds the family. Build it around the Mohéli proof: communities governing their own resources, better off for doing so.

STEP 4: COMMUNITY GOVERNANCE, PARKS & PARTNERS — TURNING THE HARM AROUND

Set expectations honestly: the levers are proven but local and partial, the harm is poverty-driven, and livelihood must accompany conservation or it will not hold.

Community-Based Conservation and the Parks

The distinctive, proven lever is **community-based conservation and co-management** — the Mohéli marine-park model — given durable structure by **marine and national park designations**. Communities governing their own resources have already halted beach mining and brought turtles back; the park framework and the expanding network are how that governance is built and secured.

Village Authority and the Living Value

The **village councils and traditional authority** are the foundation of community self-governance, and the **living value of the reefs, turtles, and beaches** — worth more alive, as fisheries and tourism, than destroyed — is the argument that makes the case to the community itself. Build through the one, and ground everything in the other.

Livelihood Alternatives and International Support

Because the harm is poverty-driven, **livelihood alternatives** — eco-tourism, sustainable fishing, alternatives to beach sand — are essential, not optional, and the **international conservation and restoration partners** fund the community conservation a poor state cannot. Pursued together — community governance, the parks, the living value, the livelihoods, and the partners — these levers turn the harm around, as Mohéli proved, island by island.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the community:** here is the reef and beach worth more alive, and the better livelihood that ends the harm and feeds the family. **For the village and traditional authority:** here is the Mohéli model your governance can build. **For the park and co-management framework:** here is a resource to bring under community protection. **For the international partners:** here is a proven model to fund and expand. **For an outside developer's assessment:** here is the harm to the reefs and parks, and the protection they carry. **The golden rule:** never blame the poor who mine the sand — offer the livelihood that replaces the harm, and ground everything in the living value of the reefs and the Mohéli proof.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, and here it is hopeful. Frame the story around **the Mohéli proof and the living reefs:** communities governing their own resources, bringing turtles back, and better off for it. Carry it through the national and Indian Ocean conservation networks, the international partners, and the community's own voice. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the living value and the proven model; never blame or shame the poor who mine sand to survive; and let the turtles, the reefs, and the Mohéli success carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message grounded in the living value, the livelihood, and the Mohéli proof, and never blaming the poor.

8A — To a village council or traditional authority: propose building community-based conservation and co-management, on the Mohéli model.

8B — To the marine/national park framework: ask to bring a threatened reef or beach under community protection.

8C — To an international conservation partner: present the case and the model, and ask for funding and support.

8D — To the coastal community: set out the living value of the reef and the livelihood alternative, and invite the governance.

8E — On livelihood alternatives: propose the eco-tourism, sustainable fishing, or sand alternatives that replace the harm.

8F — To the state's environmental authority (for an outside project): identify the harm to the reefs and parks and request assessment and protection.

8G — To a restoration partner: propose reef, mangrove, or turtle restoration paired with community governance.

8H — To the press and public: offer the Mohéli success and the living-reefs frame, and ask for coverage.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify the harm and the community driving it, and the livelihood alternative; write the one-page case (the living value, the alternative, the Mohéli model); reach the village authority and an international partner. **The fastest-moving levers:** community governance, the park framework, and the international partners. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the village and traditional authority and the community first — the harm and the power sit with them. Throughout, offer livelihood, never blame.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The tilt here is not a powerful enemy but structural poverty and a fragile state with weak enforcement. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a single victory, but the harm turned around community by community, paired with livelihood. Lean on the proven levers: community governance, the parks, the living value, the international support. In the Comoros these have already worked. Accept, honestly, that the pressures of poverty and population are structural, that the successes are local and partial, and that conservation without livelihood will not hold.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Where the harm is not community poverty but an outside interest — a developer, an illegal fishing operation, an official waving through destruction — respond through the **environmental assessment, the park protections, the international partners, and the community's own governance**. Distinguish the poor who mine sand to live, who need alternatives not blame, from those who profit from destruction, who need scrutiny. **On safety:** the Comoros is fragile but not a place of grave danger to conservation work; the risks are political and structural, not physical, so the work is open, lawful, and community-based — but always just toward the poor whose poverty drives the harm.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel. The living value and the harm feed the community governance, the park, and the livelihood alternative at once; the village authority and the international partners organise alongside; the media carries the Mohéli-proof frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the living value, and reach the village authority and a partner; **months two onward**, build the community conservation, the park, and the livelihood alternatives; **beyond**, expand the model island by island and sustain it through livelihood. The core discipline: community-governed, livelihood-paired, grounded in the living value, and never blaming the poor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Comoros is unusual in this guide, and this guide honours why: the harm is largely driven by the communities' own poverty, and the answer has, on Mohéli, genuinely worked. It does not pretend the poverty and population pressures are easily relieved, or that the state's enforcement is strong, or that the successes are more than local and partial — none of that is true. What it claims is real and hopeful: that communities governing their own resources, through community-based conservation and marine parks built on the village and traditional authority, grounded in the living value of the reefs and turtles, funded by international partners, and — crucially — paired with better livelihoods, can turn the harm around, as Mohéli did. The levers are proven but local, and the prize is the harm reversed community by community, not a single triumph. But in a poor, fragile archipelago whose harm is its own, that community-governed, livelihood-paired, living-value-grounded work — never blaming the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the proven and effective one, and it has already brought the turtles back.